

Metabolism

Metabolism was the most influential architectural movement to emerge from postwar Japan. In a nation undergoing rapid economic revival, yet still subject to natural disasters, Metabolism's practitioners envisioned it as a way to design cities and buildings in organic and repeatable ways, essentially in imitation of nature.

Those involved included Kiyonori Kikutake (1928–2011), Kisho Kurokawa (1934–2007) and Fumihiko Maki (b.1928); it was at the suggestion of their mentor, noted architect Kenzo Tange (1913–2005), that they founded Metabolism at the 1960 Tokyo World Design Conference. They created visionary designs of floating cities, spiralling structures, and flexible buildings that could be expanded in modular ways. Many were too ambitious ever to be built; but their approach is illustrated in Kurokawa's Nakagin Capsule Tower (opposite, 1970–2) in Tokyo; designed for both residential and office use, it comprises 140 identical concrete and steel capsules bolted to two armature towers.

